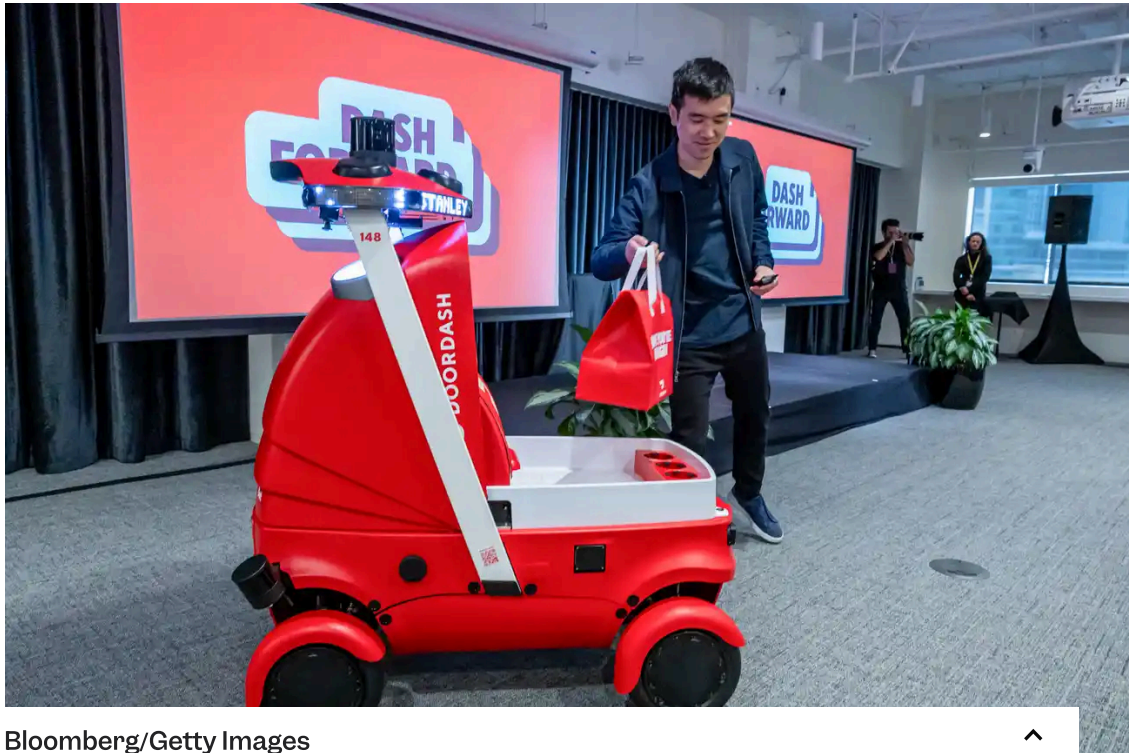


TECH

DoorDash is paying people to load its delivery robots. It points to a shortcoming of automation

By [Alex Bitter](#)

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DoorDash's delivery robots need a hand.

Some workers in areas where DoorDash is using its Dot delivery robot are receiving offers through the DoorDash app to load them up. While the vehicles can navigate miles to delivery destinations, it's the few feet between a restaurant's pickup counter and the curb outside where delivery workers intervene.

Devena Bybee, a DoorDash gig worker in Mesa, Arizona, said that she received one such offer in early July. The company is using the robots to make deliveries in the Phoenix area.

Bybee drove about two miles to a restaurant, picked up an order, and placed it in the Dot robot as it waited in the parking lot, she said. She took photos of each step to document the process, and the gig took five minutes, she said. DoorDash paid her about \$5.

Bybee was surprised that DoorDash asked her to complete the task instead of a restaurant worker who was already on-site. "I just don't see how it's efficient," she said.

How AI takes a toll on the freelancers who train, test, and refine it

On Facebook groups for DoorDash workers, some posts show screenshots of similar gig offers over the past month.

"I would never do a five-dollar order, but I was really curious about this and I was super close to the restaurant," reads one July 6 [post](#) showing a robot-loading gig at a Burger King in Scottsdale, Arizona. The poster did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

"Dashers are essential to our platform and will continue completing the majority of deliveries even as our autonomous technology scales," a DoorDash spokesperson said.

"This limited pilot is designed to support merchants during busy periods, while creating more earning opportunities for Dashers outside of traditional deliveries," the spokesperson added.

A sticking point for automation

The loading gigs are the latest example of DoorDash workers stepping in when autonomous vehicles can't complete a job on their own.

Some workers received offers from DoorDash to close open doors on [Waymo's self-driving cars](#) in Atlanta, Business Insider reported in February. Waymo plans to add a self-closing function to its vehicles in the future, the companies said at the time.

Dot, which DoorDash unveiled in September, is roughly the size of a baby stroller and can hold up to 30 pounds of cargo. The robot can navigate both roads and sidewalks to travel between restaurants and customers' homes.

Handing off orders from restaurants to robots is a challenge to the rollout of [autonomous deliveries](#), DoorDash CEO Tony Xu said last August, shortly before the company debuted Dot.

While loading an order only takes a few minutes, restaurants that receive lots of robot-delivered orders might have an incentive to outsource the task to DoorDash, said Robert Bruno, a professor of labor and employment relations at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.

DoorDash's gig workers, who are independent contractors, don't receive the same employee benefits and hourly pay rate that most restaurant workers do, Bruno said.

"Multiplied over the course of a year or more, there's probably a real savings," he said.

Bybee, the DoorDash worker in Arizona, said that the loading gig left her more confident that humans are still needed for delivery work.

"There's only so much right now that the robots can do," she said.

Do you have a story idea about DoorDash? Contact this reporter at abitter@businessinsider.com or via encrypted messaging app Signal at 808-854-4501. Use a personal email address, a nonwork WiFi network, and a nonwork device; here's our [guide to sharing information securely](#).

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